BONUS 4: 25 Wedding Checklists + Day-of Emergency Kit

Print-Ready. Use Them. Survive.

These 25 checklists are designed to be printed individually or used as a complete PDF set. Each fits on one page. They cover every major planning phase and every day-of scenario that has the potential to derail an otherwise beautiful wedding. Print what you need. Check things off. Move forward.

Checklist 1: Engagement Week Checklist

THE FIRST 7 DAYS AFTER GETTING ENGAGED

You just said yes. Now put the champagne down for 30 minutes and do these things before the planning chaos takes over. The decisions you make this week set the tone for everything that follows.

CELEBRATE FIRST

- [ ] Tell immediate family before posting on social media
- [ ] Call or visit parents on both sides before the announcement goes public
- [ ] Take 24 hours to just be engaged before the planning conversation starts

GET ALIGNED AS A COUPLE

- [ ] Have the "what kind of wedding do we actually want" conversation — big or small, local or destination, formal or relaxed
- [ ] Discuss a rough budget range before anyone else's opinions enter the room
- [ ] Agree on a rough guest count range (under 50, 50–100, 100–150, 150+)
- [ ] Talk about must-haves vs. nice-to-haves for each of you
- [ ] Decide who from each family will be consulted on major decisions

LOGISTICS

- [ ] Discuss a general timeframe (6 months out? 12? 18?)
- [ ] Start a shared note, folder, or spreadsheet for wedding information
- [ ] Set up a dedicated wedding email address (yournames2026@gmail.com)
- [ ] Check if either of you has a family venue, connection, or resource that should factor in early

SOCIAL & LEGAL

- [ ] Post the announcement when you're ready — not before you've told family
- [ ] Look up marriage license requirements in your state/county (processing times vary from same-day to 3 weeks)
- [ ] If either of you has been married before, confirm your divorce decree is final and accessible

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Checklist 2: Month 1 Foundation Checklist

THE 11 DECISIONS THAT CASCADE INTO EVERYTHING ELSE

These are the decisions that unlock every other decision. Get these right in Month 1 and the rest of the plan builds cleanly. Skip them and you'll revisit them — painfully — six months from now.

BUDGET

- [ ] Establish the total all-in budget (include honeymoon if funding simultaneously)
- [ ] Identify all contributing parties (parents, couple, others) and confirm their amounts in writing — even if it's informal
- [ ] Assign category percentages using the 50/20/30 framework (50% venue + catering, 20% photography + video, 30% everything else)
- [ ] Open a dedicated wedding checking or savings account

GUEST LIST

- [ ] Draft the full "dream list" with no editing — get every name on paper
- [ ] Separate into A-list (must invite), B-list (want to invite if room), C-list (obligation only)
- [ ] Count each list and reality-check against budget and venue capacity

VISION

- [ ] Create one shared Pinterest or Canva board — one, not seven
- [ ] Identify 3 adjectives that describe the feeling you want guests to have
- [ ] Identify the 2–3 elements that matter most to each of you (the photo, the food, the dance floor, the flowers)

VENDOR PRIORITY

- [ ] Book a venue tour for at least 3 venues within the next 3 weeks
- [ ] Research photographers in your area now — they book 12–18 months out
- [ ] Decide if you want a wedding planner or coordinator before touring venues (some venues require one)

Checklist 3: Budget Setup Checklist

SETTING UP YOUR TRACKING SYSTEM BEFORE YOU SPEND A DOLLAR

The couples who blow their budgets don't fail at math — they fail at setup. Build this system in Week 1 and every vendor conversation becomes a negotiation instead of a panic.

SYSTEM SETUP

- [ ] Choose your tracking tool: Google Sheets (free, recommended), Notion, or a dedicated wedding app
- [ ] Create columns: Category, Vendor Name, Estimated Cost, Deposit Paid, Balance Due, Due Date, Paid (Y/N), Notes
- [ ] Set up a running total that auto-calculates at the top
- [ ] Create a separate tab for payments with due dates so nothing sneaks up on you

CATEGORY BUDGETS (FILL IN YOUR NUMBERS)

- [ ] Venue & rental fees: $_____
- [ ] Catering (per person × guest count): $_____
- [ ] Bar package: $_____

- [ ] Photography: $_____
- [ ] Videography: $_____
- [ ] Flowers & decor: $_____
- [ ] Music (DJ or band): $_____
- [ ] Officiant: $_____
- [ ] Hair & makeup (bride + party): $_____
- [ ] Attire (dress, suit, alterations, accessories): $_____
- [ ] Invitations & stationery: $_____
- [ ] Transportation: $_____
- [ ] Cake & desserts: $_____
- [ ] Favors & gifts: $_____
- [ ] Rehearsal dinner: $_____
- [ ] Honeymoon (if included): $_____
- [ ] Miscellaneous / buffer (keep at 5–8% of total): $_____

DISCIPLINE RULES

- [ ] Agree: no vendor is booked without a budget check first
- [ ] Agree: any upgrade over $200 requires a 24-hour waiting period
- [ ] Set a monthly budget check-in date with your partner
- [ ] Add all deposit due dates to a shared calendar

Checklist 4: Venue Search Checklist

BEFORE, DURING, AND AFTER EVERY TOUR

Touring venues is exciting and overwhelming in equal measure. Use this checklist so you're gathering apples-to-apples information instead of vibes-to-vibes impressions.

BEFORE THE TOUR

- [ ] Confirm the date is available for your target date(s)

- [ ] Ask the per-person or flat-fee pricing range before driving there
- [ ] Ask minimum guest count requirements
- [ ] Confirm whether catering is in-house or external
- [ ] Bring a measuring tape, your phone camera, and this checklist

DURING THE TOUR — LOGISTICS

- [ ] What is the venue's maximum capacity (seated, cocktail, both)?
- [ ] Is there a rain plan / backup for outdoor ceremonies?
- [ ] How many hours does the rental include? What is the overtime rate?
- [ ] Is there a separate bridal suite and groom's room?
- [ ] What is the noise curfew?
- [ ] Is there ample parking? Is it free?
- [ ] Is the venue ADA accessible for any guests who need it?
- [ ] When is setup allowed to begin? When must everything be cleared?

DURING THE TOUR — VENDOR RULES

- [ ] Does the venue have a preferred vendor list? Is it required or recommended?
- [ ] Can you bring in outside alcohol? Is there a corkage fee?
- [ ] Are there any décor restrictions (open flames, hanging from ceiling, confetti)?
- [ ] Is there a required day-of coordinator or security?

AFTER THE TOUR

- [ ] Note your gut reaction within 24 hours while it's fresh
- [ ] Request a full itemized pricing sheet and contract template
- [ ] Ask for references from two recent weddings
- [ ] Compare side-by-side with other venues on your spreadsheet before deciding

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Checklist 5: Venue Red Flags Checklist

WALK AWAY IF YOU SEE THESE

Not every red flag is obvious in a tour. Some are in the fine print. Some are in how they answer your questions. Trust this list over your heart when they conflict.

ON THE TOUR

- [ ] They won't give you pricing until you've committed to a second meeting (pressure tactic)
- [ ] The bridal suite is a closet or bathroom with a mirror
- [ ] No clear rain backup for outdoor spaces — "we'll figure it out" is not a plan
- [ ] The venue smells like mold, mildew, or old smoke
- [ ] Staff are dismissive, distracted, or condescending during the tour
- [ ] They can't produce a vendor reference list when asked

IN THE CONTRACT

- [ ] Cancellation policy returns less than 50% of the deposit under any circumstance
- [ ] "Force majeure" clause doesn't cover pandemic, weather, or venue closure scenarios
- [ ] No itemized breakdown — just one large flat fee with no detail
- [ ] Price can be adjusted by the venue within 60 days of the wedding
- [ ] Required vendor list with no price transparency (kickbacks suspected)
- [ ] No written policy on overtime charges — verbal assurances only

GUT CHECK

- [ ] You feel pressured to book same-day
- [ ] They can't quickly answer a basic logistics question
- [ ] The coordinator who did your tour "may not be the one assigned to your wedding"
- [ ] Reviews mention the same specific problem more than twice

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Checklist 6: Photographer Hiring Checklist

PORTFOLIO REVIEW + INTERVIEW QUESTIONS + CONTRACT MUST-HAVES

Your photographer is the only vendor whose work you will use every day for the rest of your life. This checklist treats the hire accordingly.

PORTFOLIO REVIEW (DO THIS BEFORE YOU CONTACT ANYONE)

- [ ] Review at least two complete wedding galleries — not just highlight reels
- [ ] Confirm their editing style matches what you want (light and airy vs. moody and dark vs. true-to-life)
- [ ] Check indoor, outdoor, and low-light photos from the same photographer
- [ ] Look at how they photograph people who look like you and your partner
- [ ] Read every publicly available review — note any pattern, positive or negative

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS

- [ ] How many weddings have you shot at our venue or a similar one?
- [ ] Will you be the photographer, or will you send an associate? (This is critical — get the answer in writing)
- [ ] How many images will we receive, and in what timeframe?
- [ ] Do you bring backup equipment to every wedding?
- [ ] What happens if you have a medical emergency on our wedding day?
- [ ] What is your shooting and editing style? Walk me through a typical wedding day.
- [ ] Can we see a full gallery from a recent wedding at an indoor venue?

CONTRACT MUST-HAVES

- [ ] Photographer name specified — not just "a photographer from [studio name]"
- [ ] Number of hours covered
- [ ] Minimum image delivery count
- [ ] Delivery timeline (industry standard: 6–10 weeks)
- [ ] Image rights and printing permissions clearly stated
- [ ] Cancellation policy with specific refund terms

- [ ] What happens if photographer is incapacitated (backup plan in writing)
- [ ] Second shooter included or not (clarify)

Checklist 7: Catering Interview Checklist

ALL-IN PRICING + TASTING PROTOCOL + CONTRACT NON-NEGOTIABLES

Food is what your guests talk about for years. This checklist ensures you're comparing true all-in costs, not teaser prices.

BEFORE THE MEETING

- [ ] Get the per-person price range via email before booking the meeting
- [ ] Confirm they have availability for your date
- [ ] Ask if a tasting is included or costs extra

PRICING QUESTIONS (GET EVERY ANSWER IN WRITING)

- [ ] What is the per-person cost for your recommended package?
- [ ] What is included: appetizers, plated dinner, buffet, or stations?
- [ ] Is the bar package separate? What are the options and pricing?
- [ ] What are the service fees, gratuity percentages, and taxes — and are they included in the per-person quote?
- [ ] Is cake cutting included or an additional fee?
- [ ] Is there a children's plate option at a reduced rate?
- [ ] What is the vendor meal cost for photographers, coordinators, DJ?
- [ ] Is there a minimum guest count?
- [ ] What is the overtime rate if dinner service runs long?

THE TASTING

- [ ] Taste the actual menu options you're considering — not a special tasting menu
- [ ] Evaluate temperature (was it hot when it arrived?), presentation, and portion size
- [ ] Bring your partner and at least one other person for a second opinion

- [ ] Ask who will be the lead caterer on your wedding day

CONTRACT

- [ ] Final guest count deadline specified (usually 2 weeks out)
- [ ] Overage policy if attendance exceeds estimate
- [ ] All fees itemized, not bundled
- [ ] Deposit amount and refund terms clearly stated

Checklist 8: Florist Brief Checklist

WHAT TO BRING TO EVERY FLORIST MEETING

The couples who overspend on flowers are the ones who walk into a florist meeting with no brief. This checklist ensures you walk in with a plan and walk out with a realistic quote.

WHAT TO BRING

- [ ] Your Pinterest inspiration board (3–5 images max — curated, not a flood)
- [ ] A written list of every floral item you need (bouquets, boutonnieres, centerpieces, ceremony arch, etc.)
- [ ] Your color palette (swatches or Pantone references if possible)
- [ ] Venue dimensions or a floor plan if available
- [ ] Your budget number — say it out loud in the meeting

QUESTIONS TO ASK

- [ ] Can you work within a $_____ budget? What would that look like?
- [ ] Which flowers on my inspiration board are in season during my wedding month?
- [ ] What are your most cost-effective substitutions that achieve the same look?
- [ ] Do you rent or purchase structural elements (arches, vessels, stands)?
- [ ] Do you handle setup and breakdown, and is that included in the quote?
- [ ] Will you be the one designing and delivering, or will it be a team member?
- [ ] What is your cancellation policy?

AFTER THE MEETING

- [ ] Get an itemized quote in writing — line by line, not a single total
- [ ] Ask for a sample centerpiece at a specific price point before committing
- [ ] Compare at least 2–3 florist quotes before deciding
- [ ] Ask if you can do a partial DIY (bulk grocery store flowers for cocktail tables) to reduce cost

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Checklist 9: DJ/Band Vetting Checklist

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS + LIVE PERFORMANCE EVALUATION

The DJ or band controls the energy of your entire reception. A bad hire ruins a beautiful wedding. A great one makes people talk about it for decades.

RESEARCH PHASE

- [ ] Watch at least one video of them performing at a wedding (not a produced promo — raw footage)
- [ ] Read reviews specifically mentioning how they read the room and managed transitions
- [ ] Confirm they have a backup plan if equipment fails or a band member cancels

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS — DJ

- [ ] Do you use professional-grade equipment? What is your backup setup?
- [ ] Will you take our do-not-play list seriously?
- [ ] How do you handle guest requests during the reception?
- [ ] Will you MC the event (announcing first dance, dinner, etc.) or do we need a separate MC?
- [ ] Do you bring your own lighting, or is that extra?
- [ ] How early do you arrive for setup and soundcheck?
- [ ] Can we see your standard contract?

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS — BAND

- [ ] How many musicians are in the group? Who is the lead singer?
- [ ] What is your set list, and how many songs do you know?

- [ ] Do you play recorded music during breaks?
- [ ] What is your volume level — can it be adjusted for dinner vs. dancing?
- [ ] What is your cancellation policy if a key member can't perform?
- [ ] What do you require from the venue (power, staging, load-in time)?

CONTRACT

- [ ] Start and end time confirmed
- [ ] Number of breaks and their duration
- [ ] Overtime rate per hour
- [ ] Cancellation policy and deposit terms
- [ ] Specific name of DJ or lead performer — not "talent to be determined"

Checklist 10: Hair & Makeup Trial Checklist

WHAT TO ASSESS, WHAT TO BRING, WHAT TO DECIDE

The trial is not a luxury — it's an insurance policy. This checklist maximizes what you get out of it.

WHAT TO BRING TO THE TRIAL

- [ ] Inspiration photos (3–5 images of the look you want — including hair up, hair down, specific makeup references)
- [ ] Your veil or headpiece if you have it
- [ ] The earrings and necklace you plan to wear
- [ ] Any allergy or skin sensitivity information
- [ ] A dress with a similar neckline to your wedding gown (or a strapless top)

WHAT TO EVALUATE DURING THE TRIAL

- [ ] Does the artist listen, or do they push their preferred style?
- [ ] Does your hair hold when you move, toss your head, or walk quickly?
- [ ] Does the makeup look good in natural light AND phone camera flash?
- [ ] Does your skin feel comfortable, or is it caked or tight?

- [ ] How long did the service take? (This matters for day-of scheduling)
- [ ] Does the look feel like you, or like a costume?

AFTER THE TRIAL — QUESTIONS TO CONFIRM

- [ ] Can you bring the bridesmaids and mother of the bride — and what is the per-person rate?
- [ ] What is the travel fee to come to the getting-ready location?
- [ ] What time do you need to start to finish the full party before the ceremony?
- [ ] What products are used? (Important for skin sensitivities and touch-up matching)
- [ ] What is the touch-up kit they recommend for the day?

WHAT TO DOCUMENT

- [ ] Take photos in multiple light conditions at the end of the trial
- [ ] Write down every product used so you can purchase for touch-ups
- [ ] Note what you want adjusted before the wedding day

Checklist 11: Officiant Meeting Checklist

CEREMONY PLANNING + LEGAL REQUIREMENTS + SCRIPT REVIEW

Most couples underplan the ceremony and overplan the reception. This checklist makes sure the 20-minute ceremony that starts your marriage is as intentional as everything else.

LEGAL REQUIREMENTS

- [ ] Confirm your officiant is legally ordained in your state
- [ ] Know your state's marriage license requirements (waiting periods, expiration dates, required witnesses)
- [ ] Confirm who signs the license on the day (officiant, couple, two witnesses)
- [ ] Confirm where the license must be filed and the timeline (usually within 3–10 days of the wedding)
- [ ] If marrying abroad or in another state, research local requirements separately

CEREMONY PLANNING QUESTIONS

- [ ] What is your ceremony style (religious, secular, interfaith, humanist)?
- [ ] Do you write custom ceremonies or use a standard script?
- [ ] Can we review and edit the script before the wedding day?
- [ ] Will you do a rehearsal with us and the wedding party?
- [ ] How long will the ceremony be?
- [ ] Will you use a microphone? What audio setup do you need?

CONTENT TO DISCUSS

- [ ] Readings — who, what, and where in the ceremony
- [ ] Vows — writing your own or using traditional language?
- [ ] Unity ritual — candle, sand, ring warming, wine, or none?
- [ ] Any cultural or religious elements to incorporate
- [ ] How you want to be introduced at the end ("for the first time as…")

CONTRACT

- [ ] Fee and deposit terms
- [ ] Cancellation policy
- [ ] Confirm date, time, and location in writing
- [ ] Confirm rehearsal date and whether it's included in the fee

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Checklist 12: Guest List Management Checklist

A/B/C TIERS + TRACKING + THE HARD CONVERSATIONS

The guest list is where most budget disasters begin. This checklist gives you a process instead of an argument.

BUILDING THE LISTS

- [ ] Each partner writes their own full list independently — no editing each other yet

- [ ] Combine and deduplicate
- [ ] Label every name: A (must invite), B (want to invite), C (obligation / parental request)
- [ ] Count each tier and reality-check against your per-person catering cost and venue capacity

TRACKING SETUP

- [ ] Create a spreadsheet with columns: Name, Address, Tier, Invite Sent, RSVP (Y/N/No Response), Dietary Restriction, Table Assignment, Gift (Y/N), Thank You Sent
- [ ] Add a "notes" column for anything unusual (plus-ones, children, accessibility needs)
- [ ] Highlight anyone whose address you don't have — collect addresses early, not last minute

THE HARD CONVERSATIONS

- [ ] Decide on a clear plus-one policy (married/engaged only? anyone over 2 years together? open plus-ones?)
- [ ] Decide on a children policy (under 3 only? no children? all welcome?)
- [ ] Agree on how to handle parental additions — set a firm cap number for each family
- [ ] If the B-list is used, agree on when to send those invitations (after first-wave RSVPs decline)

ONGOING MANAGEMENT

- [ ] Update RSVPs in the spreadsheet within 24 hours of receiving them
- [ ] Send RSVP reminders to non-responders 2 weeks before the deadline
- [ ] Keep a running count for catering: confirmed yes, confirmed no, pending

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Checklist 13: Invitation Mailing Checklist

ASSEMBLY + POSTAGE + TIMELINE + THE DETAILS EVERYONE FORGETS

Invitations are the first physical thing your guests receive. This checklist keeps the process from becoming a weekend-ruining stuffing marathon.

ORDER AND DELIVERY

- [ ] Order invitations at least 12 weeks before the wedding

- [ ] Order 10–15% more than your final guest count (you will need extras)
- [ ] Order inner and outer envelopes if using a traditional format
- [ ] Proofread every line — date, time, venue address, RSVP date, and website URL — three times before ordering

BEFORE STUFFING

- [ ] Take one complete assembled invitation to the post office for weighing BEFORE buying all stamps
- [ ] Purchase enough stamps for both outgoing and RSVP return envelopes
- [ ] Print or calligraph all envelope addresses before the stuffing session
- [ ] Set up an assembly line: insert cards in correct order, seal, stamp, address

ASSEMBLY ORDER (INSIDE THE OUTER ENVELOPE)

- [ ] Invitation (face up, facing the recipient when opened)
- [ ] Details card / accommodations card
- [ ] RSVP card with pre-stamped return envelope
- [ ] Any inserts (map, menu choices, etc.)

MAILING TIMELINE

- [ ] Local guests: mail 8 weeks before the wedding
- [ ] Out-of-town guests: mail 10–12 weeks before
- [ ] Destination wedding: mail 12–16 weeks before
- [ ] Set your RSVP deadline 3–4 weeks before the wedding (gives you time to chase)

AFTER MAILING

- [ ] Track the mailing date so you know when to start watching for RSVPs
- [ ] Send digital save-the-dates to anyone whose mailed invitation might be lost
- [ ] Keep 3–5 extras unsealed in case of addressing errors or additions

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Checklist 14: Wedding Website Checklist

EVERYTHING YOUR SITE NEEDS TO INCLUDE (AND WHAT TO LEAVE OFF)

Your wedding website replaces 90% of the phone calls you'd otherwise field from confused guests. Build it completely, share it early.

ESSENTIAL PAGES

- [ ] Home page: names, date, location, link to RSVP
- [ ] Our Story: brief, warm, readable in under 2 minutes
- [ ] Event Details: ceremony time, location + address + Google Maps link, cocktail hour, reception details
- [ ] Accommodations: hotel block information with booking link and code, deadline, and alternatives
- [ ] Travel: driving directions, nearest airports, parking at the venue, rideshare notes
- [ ] Registry: links to all registries + any charitable registry
- [ ] RSVP form: name, attendance confirmation, meal choice, dietary restrictions, plus-one name
- [ ] FAQ page: this is the most underused and most valuable page on wedding websites

FAQ PAGE — ANSWER THESE QUESTIONS PROACTIVELY

- [ ] What should I wear? (Dress code with examples)
- [ ] Are children invited?
- [ ] Is there parking at the venue?
- [ ] Can I take photos during the ceremony?
- [ ] Where are you registered?
- [ ] What time should I arrive?
- [ ] Is there a shuttle or transportation?
- [ ] What happens if I have a dietary restriction?

TECHNICAL

- [ ] Password-protect the site if you prefer privacy (especially for the ceremony location)
- [ ] Test the RSVP form on mobile — that's how most guests will use it

- [ ] Check that the hotel block link works correctly
- [ ] Launch the site when save-the-dates go out

Checklist 15: Hotel Block Checklist

NEGOTIATION + COMMUNICATION + TRACKING

Hotel blocks are one of the most administratively neglected parts of wedding planning. This checklist makes it manageable.

CHOOSING A HOTEL

- [ ] Identify 2–3 hotels within reasonable distance of the venue (under 10 minutes preferred)
- [ ] Look for hotels with a free or cheap shuttle as a bonus
- [ ] Aim for a range: one mid-range and one budget option if possible

NEGOTIATING THE BLOCK

- [ ] Ask for a "room block" with an "attrition clause" you understand — know what happens if rooms go unbooked
- [ ] Negotiate for: complimentary welcome bag delivery, a free suite for the couple (if booking 10+ rooms), flexible cutoff date (guests can book until 30 days before the wedding)
- [ ] Get the block rate in writing — confirm it includes taxes or clarify if not
- [ ] Confirm the hotel allows rooms to be added if the block sells out

COMMUNICATION TO GUESTS

- [ ] Include hotel block information on your wedding website
- [ ] Include accommodations card in invitations
- [ ] Remind guests of the booking deadline in a website update or email blast
- [ ] Send a second reminder 4 weeks before the cutoff date

TRACKING

- [ ] Check in with the hotel monthly to see how many rooms have been booked

- [ ] If uptake is low, message guests directly 6 weeks out with the booking link
- [ ] Confirm total reserved rooms 2 weeks before the cutoff in case attrition penalties apply
- [ ] Get a final rooming list from the hotel one week before the wedding

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Checklist 16: Out-of-Town Guest Checklist

WELCOME BAGS + ITINERARY + LOGISTICS

Out-of-town guests are making a significant investment to be there. This checklist makes sure they feel like it was worth every mile.

WELCOME BAG CONTENTS

- [ ] Handwritten welcome note from the couple
- [ ] Local snack or treat (something the area is known for)
- [ ] Bottle of water (travel dehydrates people)
- [ ] Ibuprofen or small pain reliever packet
- [ ] Wedding weekend itinerary with all dates, times, and addresses
- [ ] Venue address and parking information
- [ ] Restaurant recommendations for Friday dinner and Sunday brunch
- [ ] Rideshare or transportation information
- [ ] Small personal touch (photo, local map, custom item)

LOGISTICS TO COMMUNICATE

- [ ] Shuttle schedule to/from venue (if applicable) — times and pickup locations
- [ ] Rehearsal dinner invitation (if extended to out-of-towners)
- [ ] Sunday brunch invitation (if hosted) — time and location
- [ ] Childcare options if applicable
- [ ] Nearest urgent care, pharmacy, and grocery store to the hotel

WELCOME BAG DELIVERY

- [ ] Confirm with hotel how and when to drop off bags (usually 2 days before or day-of)

- [ ] Bring a typed or printed guest list so the front desk can match bags to names
- [ ] Confirm bags will not be delivered until guests check in (not left on a cart)
- [ ] Label each bag clearly with the guest name

Checklist 17: 6-Month Countdown Checklist

ALL PRIORITY TASKS FOR THE 6-MONTH MARK

Six months out, the foundational vendors should be locked. This checklist confirms what's done and what's urgent.

CONFIRM BOOKED

- [ ] Venue — contract signed, deposit paid
- [ ] Photographer — contract signed, deposit paid
- [ ] Catering — contract signed, deposit paid
- [ ] DJ or band — contract signed, deposit paid
- [ ] Officiant — confirmed and reserved

BOOK NOW

- [ ] Florist — schedule consultations this month
- [ ] Hair & makeup — schedule trial and confirm for wedding day
- [ ] Videographer (if applicable) — book now, they go fast
- [ ] Transportation (limo, trolley, party bus) — availability gets tight

GUEST LIST & INVITATIONS

- [ ] Finalize A-list guest count
- [ ] Collect all mailing addresses (use a Google Form to make it easy)
- [ ] Order invitations — they take 4–6 weeks to produce
- [ ] Finalize and launch wedding website

ATTIRE

- [ ] Order wedding dress (alterations take 2–3 months; order no later than 6 months out)
- [ ] Begin researching bridesmaids dresses
- [ ] Schedule suit or tux fittings for the couple and groomsmen

REGISTRY & HONEYMOON

- [ ] Complete registry at 2–3 sources
- [ ] Begin booking honeymoon if traveling internationally (visas, flights, accommodations)

Checklist 18: 3-Month Final Push Checklist

ADMIN SPRINT + VENDOR CALLS + EVERY DETAIL LOCKED

Three months out is when couples either get ahead of the details or start drowning in them. This checklist is your sprint plan.

VENDOR CONFIRMATION

- [ ] Send confirmation emails to all vendors — verify date, time, location, and load-in
- [ ] Schedule final meetings with florist, caterer, and venue coordinator
- [ ] Confirm music meeting with DJ or band — finalize ceremony songs, first dance, dinner playlist
- [ ] Confirm hair and makeup schedule — finalize start time based on party size

CEREMONY PLANNING

- [ ] Submit final ceremony script to officiant for review
- [ ] Finalize all readings and who is delivering them
- [ ] Plan the processional order
- [ ] Confirm musician or DJ playlist for ceremony (processional, signing, recessional)

RECEPTION PLANNING

- [ ] Finalize menu selections with caterer
- [ ] Plan reception timeline with your coordinator or planner

- [ ] Determine toasts — who, in what order, with a 3-minute time limit guidance
- [ ] Plan first dance, parent dances, and any special dances

LOGISTICS

- [ ] Book hotel room for wedding night
- [ ] Finalize guest transportation and share details on the website
- [ ] Order favors, escort cards, and any day-of stationery
- [ ] Purchase or order guest book, unity candle, ring box, and any ceremony items

PERSONAL

- [ ] Begin wedding day beauty routine (skin care, hair treatments) in earnest
- [ ] Schedule final dress fitting
- [ ] Write or draft personal vows if doing so

Checklist 19: Seating Chart Checklist

STEP-BY-STEP FROM RSVP DEADLINE TO FINAL CHART

The seating chart is the administrative peak of wedding planning. This process minimizes the time you spend on it and the drama it creates.

AFTER THE RSVP DEADLINE

- [ ] Compile all RSVPs — confirmed yes list only
- [ ] Note dietary restrictions next to each name
- [ ] Note mobility needs (guests who need to be near an exit or accessible table)
- [ ] Group guests by relationship: family by side, friends by group, work colleagues together

LOGISTICS FIRST

- [ ] Get the final floor plan from your venue with table numbers and positions
- [ ] Know the table sizes and capacities (6-tops? 8-tops? 10-tops?)
- [ ] Designate sweetheart or head table — determine who sits there

- [ ] Identify which tables are near the dance floor (high energy) vs. far (older guests, families with young children)

BUILDING THE CHART

- [ ] Start with VIPs and family — parents, grandparents, wedding party (if not at head table)
- [ ] Place elderly or mobility-limited guests near exits and restrooms
- [ ] Keep feuding family members on opposite sides of the room (this is not optional)
- [ ] Fill in friend groups — people who know each other or will enjoy meeting each other
- [ ] Fill gaps last — use your B-list clusters and work colleagues

FINAL REVIEW

- [ ] Do a final count: total guests assigned = total yes RSVPs
- [ ] Have your partner review for anyone misplaced
- [ ] Send to your venue coordinator with dietary notes by the required deadline
- [ ] Create escort cards or a seating display — finalize names after chart is approved

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Checklist 20: Final Vendor Confirmation Checklist

2-WEEK-OUT CALLS + EMAILS + WHAT TO CONFIRM WITH EACH

Two weeks out, every vendor needs a confirmation call or email. This checklist tells you exactly what to confirm with each.

EVERY VENDOR — UNIVERSAL CONFIRMATIONS

- [ ] Date: confirm it
- [ ] Location: full address, including any access notes (load dock, parking lot, gate code)
- [ ] Start time: when they arrive, not when they start performing
- [ ] Your cell number on file as the day-of contact
- [ ] Confirm who specifically will be there (not "someone from our team")

VENUE COORDINATOR

- [ ] Final guest count submitted?
- [ ] Timeline reviewed and approved?
- [ ] Setup and breakdown times confirmed?
- [ ] Final payment due date confirmed?

CATERER

- [ ] Final headcount and meal selections received?
- [ ] Dietary restrictions communicated to the kitchen?
- [ ] Vendor meals arranged for photographer, DJ, coordinator?
- [ ] Timeline for cocktail hour, dinner service, and cake cutting confirmed?

PHOTOGRAPHER + VIDEOGRAPHER

- [ ] Shot list delivered?
- [ ] Timeline and must-have moments reviewed?
- [ ] Second shooter arriving with primary photographer?
- [ ] Backup equipment confirmed?

DJ / BAND

- [ ] Do-not-play list submitted?
- [ ] Must-play list submitted?
- [ ] MC duties and announcements confirmed?
- [ ] Load-in time and parking confirmed with venue?

FLORIST

- [ ] Delivery time and location confirmed?
- [ ] Someone confirmed to receive flowers at the venue?
- [ ] Boutonnieres: who gets them, and who is pinning them?

HAIR & MAKEUP

- [ ] Schedule confirmed — every person in the party, in order?

- [ ] Location address confirmed?
- [ ] Touch-up kit items confirmed?

Checklist 21: 30-Day Sprint Checklist

COMPLETE WEEK-BY-WEEK

The final 30 days are a series of closing loops. This week-by-week plan keeps the pace manageable.

4 WEEKS OUT

- [ ] Chase all non-responding RSVPs — call or text personally
- [ ] Submit final guest count to caterer and venue
- [ ] Complete seating chart first draft
- [ ] Finalize and order escort cards or seating chart display
- [ ] Prepare tip envelopes (label and stuff)
- [ ] Confirm rehearsal dinner details — venue, time, invites sent

3 WEEKS OUT

- [ ] Send wedding day timeline to all vendors
- [ ] Finalize ceremony program if printing one
- [ ] Schedule final dress fitting
- [ ] Confirm hotel block — send booking reminder to any guests who haven't booked
- [ ] Write or finalize personal vows

2 WEEKS OUT

- [ ] Complete all vendor confirmation calls and emails (see Checklist 20)
- [ ] Submit final dietary restrictions to caterer
- [ ] Drop off welcome bags to hotel if not doing day-of delivery
- [ ] Break in your wedding shoes (wear them 30 minutes per day)
- [ ] Assign day-of task roles to trusted people (who holds the rings, who coordinates transportation, who handles vendor tips)

1 WEEK OUT

- [ ] Pick up wedding dress from alterations
- [ ] Confirm rehearsal logistics
- [ ] Charge all devices you plan to use
- [ ] Prepare the day-of emergency kit
- [ ] Pack for the honeymoon (or send bags ahead if traveling immediately after)
- [ ] Write notes to your partner, parents, and wedding party if you want to deliver them on the morning

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Checklist 22: Night-Before Checklist

LOGISTICS + EMOTIONAL PREP + SLEEP

The night before is not the time to problem-solve. It's the time to confirm everything is in order, hand off responsibility, and rest.

LOGISTICS

- [ ] Wedding dress hung, steamed, and ready — not in a bag
- [ ] Suit or tuxedo pressed and hung — shoes polished
- [ ] All jewelry laid out
- [ ] Emergency kit packed and accessible
- [ ] Tip envelopes in the emergency kit, labeled
- [ ] Phone charged overnight
- [ ] Marriage license located and accessible (give it to someone reliable)
- [ ] Next-day transportation arranged — who is driving you, and where?
- [ ] Hotel or venue arrival time confirmed and alarm set

DELEGATE AND LET GO

- [ ] Assign one person to manage vendor arrivals — not you
- [ ] Assign one person to handle any day-of problem that arises — not you

- [ ] Share the full vendor contact sheet with your coordinator or point person
- [ ] Ask this person to come to you only if it absolutely requires you. Everything else is theirs.

EMOTIONAL PREP

- [ ] Eat a real dinner — tomorrow morning will be rushed and emotion-filled
- [ ] Limit alcohol — this is not the night to be dehydrated and hungover
- [ ] Protect your voice if you're saying vows or giving a speech
- [ ] Have a conversation with your partner if you need to — or give each other space if that serves you better
- [ ] Set a real bedtime and honor it

Checklist 23: Wedding Morning Checklist

HOUR-BY-HOUR FOR THE COUPLE AND WEDDING PARTY

This is the schedule and task list for wedding morning. Customize the times to match your ceremony start, and share it with your wedding party in advance.

H-6 HOURS BEFORE CEREMONY

- [ ] Wake up. Eat a real breakfast — eggs, toast, protein. Not just coffee.
- [ ] Shower and wash hair if not done the night before
- [ ] Apply base moisturizer and eye drops if wearing contacts
- [ ] Hair and makeup begins for the first person in the schedule

H-4 HOURS BEFORE CEREMONY

- [ ] All wedding party members present at the getting-ready location
- [ ] Boutonnieres, corsages, and personal flowers arrive — confirm with florist
- [ ] Deliver or assign someone to deliver welcome bags to hotel if not already done

H-3 HOURS BEFORE CEREMONY

- [ ] First dress check — steamer accessible and ready

- [ ] Confirm wedding party has all their items: shoes, accessories, vows if applicable
- [ ] Take detail photos with photographer (dress, rings, shoes, invitation, flowers)

H-2 HOURS BEFORE CEREMONY

- [ ] Getting-ready photos of the couple and party
- [ ] Bride or partner gets into dress / suit
- [ ] Confirm transportation is on schedule

H-1 HOUR BEFORE CEREMONY

- [ ] Touch-up and final looks
- [ ] Deliver tip envelopes to coordinator or designated person
- [ ] Marriage license handed to officiant or witness
- [ ] Personal notes or letters exchanged if you've written them
- [ ] First look photos if planned
- [ ] Wedding party portraits

H-30 MINUTES BEFORE CEREMONY

- [ ] Wedding party in position — calm and ready
- [ ] Ceremony music confirmed with DJ or musician
- [ ] All personal items (vow cards, rings) confirmed with best person/maid of honor
- [ ] Take one quiet moment with your partner or by yourself

Checklist 24: Vendor Tip Envelope Checklist

EVERY VENDOR, SUGGESTED AMOUNT, WHO DELIVERS IT

Tipping wedding vendors is standard practice and expected. This checklist removes the awkward last-minute scramble.

PREPARE ENVELOPES (2 WEEKS OUT)

- [ ] Label each envelope with the vendor's name and role

- [ ] Place cash inside — tips should always be cash
- [ ] Store all envelopes together in your emergency kit until the day-of
- [ ] Assign one person (coordinator, maid of honor, or family member) to distribute — not the couple

SUGGESTED TIP AMOUNTS

VENDOR	SUGGESTED TIP	NOTES
Photographer (lead)	$200–$400	Based on quality and hours worked
Photographer (second shooter)	$75–$150	Separate envelope
Videographer	$150–$300	
DJ	$150–$300	More if they were exceptional
Band (per musician)	$50–$100 each	Separate envelopes per person
Catering staff (total)	15–20% of food cost if gratuity not included	Confirm if gratuity is already in contract
Hair stylist	20% of service cost	
Makeup artist	20% of service cost	
Wedding coordinator / planner	$200–$500	
Florist delivery staff	$20–$50 per person	
Transportation driver	15–20% of total cost	
Officiant	$100–$200 (if not a friend)	Not needed if donation to house of worship
Venue staff / captain	$100–$200	Confirm if gratuity is already included

DELIVERY PROTOCOL

- [ ] Coordinator receives their envelope at the end of the day from the couple or family

- [ ] All other envelopes delivered by your designated person at the END of service — not before
- [ ] Catering gratuity: confirm if already included in contract before doubling up

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Checklist 25: Post-Wedding Week Checklist

RETURNS, LICENSE, DRESS, THANK-YOUS, AND CLOSING THE LOOP

The week after the wedding is a mix of bliss and administrivia. This checklist prevents anything important from being forgotten in the honeymoon haze.

LEGAL

- [ ] Marriage license filed by the officiant (confirm they know the deadline and process)
- [ ] Order certified copies of the marriage certificate — you'll need multiple originals for name change and insurance
- [ ] Confirm when to expect the certified copies (usually 2–4 weeks)

NAME CHANGE (IF APPLICABLE)

- [ ] Social Security Administration first (everything else follows)
- [ ] Driver's license or state ID
- [ ] Passport (can take 4–6 weeks; do not book international travel with name change pending)
- [ ] Bank accounts and credit cards
- [ ] Employer records
- [ ] Insurance policies
- [ ] Voter registration

RENTALS AND RETURNS

- [ ] Return tuxedo or suit rentals (usually within 24–48 hours)
- [ ] Return any borrowed items: jewelry, decor, family heirlooms
- [ ] Retrieve items left at the venue (guest book, card box, ceremony items)
- [ ] Return rental decor (linens, chargers, lounge furniture)

WEDDING DRESS

- [ ] Schedule professional cleaning and preservation within 2 weeks of the wedding — the longer you wait, the harder stains set
- [ ] Research preservation boxes vs. hanging storage

THANK-YOUS

- [ ] Begin writing within one week, even if you can't mail them all
- [ ] Reference the specific gift in every note — "the Dutch oven" not "your generous gift"
- [ ] Aim to complete and mail all notes within 8 weeks of the wedding
- [ ] Track who has been thanked in your gift spreadsheet

VENDOR REVIEWS

- [ ] Leave Google, Yelp, and The Knot reviews for every vendor — good or honest
- [ ] Share wedding photos with vendors (especially photographers and florists) if you're comfortable — they use them for marketing
- [ ] Reach out to your planner or coordinator with feedback

The Day-of Emergency Kit: Complete Packing List

40 Items. Every One Has Saved a Wedding.

Pack this kit the night before. Assign it to your maid of honor, best person, or a trusted family member — not to yourself. The couple should never be the one rummaging through a bag when something goes wrong. Every item below has been pulled from a real wedding emergency. They earn their spot.

CATEGORY 1: CLOTHING & APPEARANCE (10 ITEMS)

- [ ] **Fashion tape (double-sided)** — For gaping necklines, falling straps, and any dress that fit perfectly during the fitting and is now misbehaving. KMS Tape or Hollywood Fashion Tape are the industry standards.
- [ ] **Safety pins (assorted sizes, at least 12)** — Broken bustles, missing buttons, popped hems. The safety pin has saved more weddings than any single vendor.
- [ ] **Stain remover pen or wipe (Tide To Go or Carbona)** — Sauce at cocktail hour. Coffee on the morning of. Lipstick from the grandmother's kiss.
- [ ] **White chalk or white shoe polish pen** — For small scuffs or yellowing spots on a white gown. Covers more than you'd expect.
- [ ] **Needle and thread (white, ivory, and black)** — For a seam that gives up mid-reception. A basic sewing kit from a hotel room also works.
- [ ] **Lint roller** — Pet hair on a dark suit. Cat fur on a navy bridesmaid dress. Every time.
- [ ] **Clear nail polish** — Stops a run in stockings from traveling. Also works as emergency button adhesive.
- [ ] **Bobby pins and clear elastics** — The hairstyle that is perfect in photos starts coming undone by 9pm. These are the fix.
- [ ] **Blotting papers** — Heat, nerves, and dancing produce sweat. Blotting papers are invisible in photos.
- [ ] **Lip color for touch-ups** — Whatever shade was used at hair and makeup. Write the product name on a sticky note and attach it to the tube.

CATEGORY 2: HEALTH & COMFORT (10 ITEMS)

- [ ] **Ibuprofen or acetaminophen (full-size)** — Headaches, back pain from heels, and emotional tension headaches are all real. Have both options.
- [ ] **Antacid tablets (Tums or Rolaids)** — Nerves produce stomach acid. Rich food and open bar continue the story.
- [ ] **Antihistamine (Benadryl or generic)** — Unexpected allergic reaction to a flower, a fabric, or a food. Also useful for guests.
- [ ] **Bandages (assorted) and blister pads** — Heels are beautiful and brutal. Blister pads (Compeed brand specifically) can change the course of a night.
- [ ] **Breath mints or spray** — Not gum. You cannot chew gum during ceremony photos.
- [ ] **Tampons and pads** — The stress of wedding planning can trigger early cycles. It happens more than anyone admits.
- [ ] **Eye drops** — For contact lens wearers who cry and for anyone in an outdoor ceremony with pollen or wind.
- [ ] **Deodorant (travel-size, clear)** — One more application before the ceremony. The original application from 7am is not going to survive the first dance.
- [ ] **Mini sewing kit with scissors** — Distinct from the needle and thread above — these scissors are for trimming threads, cutting ties, or dealing with a bustle crisis.
- [ ] **Hand lotion (unscented)** — Dry hands show in ring photos. Dry knuckles crack in winter ceremonies. Small tube, major quality of life.

CATEGORY 3: TECHNOLOGY & ADMIN (8 ITEMS)

- [ ] **Printed wedding day timeline (5 copies)** — When the phone dies or signal drops, paper doesn't fail. One for the coordinator, one for the DJ, one for the caterer, one for the couple's person, one spare.
- [ ] **Printed vendor contact sheet** — Every vendor's name, company, cell phone, and arrival time in one place. The coordinator has it. Your point person has it. Nobody is guessing.
- [ ] **Tip envelopes (labeled and stuffed with cash)** — Pre-prepared. Pre-labeled. Handed to the designated distributor in the morning. Do not leave this to end-of-night improvisation.
- [ ] **Portable phone charger (fully charged)** — The wedding photographer's phone, the maid of honor's phone, and your phone will all hit 10% before the reception is over.

- [ ] **Universal charging cable (USB-C and Lightning)** — Because everyone has a different phone.
- [ ] **Pen and small notepad** — For last-minute additions to the timeline, vendor notes, or the moment someone gives you their address for a thank-you card.
- [ ] **Marriage license** — In a clear folder or sleeve. Not in a bag, not in a car — in the kit, confirmed before you leave for the venue.
- [ ] **Photo of the seating chart or guest list** — In case you need to redirect a confused guest and the display gets knocked over.

CATEGORY 4: VENUE & ENVIRONMENT (6 ITEMS)

- [ ] **Mini steamer or wrinkle-release spray** — The dress was perfect when it was packed. Three hours in a car or hanging bag will introduce wrinkles. A mini steamer fixes them in 10 minutes.
- [ ] **Clear umbrella** — Outdoor ceremonies happen in optimistic weather forecasts. One clear umbrella keeps photos beautiful in light rain.
- [ ] **Extra candle lighter (long-neck)** — Unity candles and table votives go out. The venue lighter disappears.
- [ ] **White floral tape and extra flower stems** — If a boutonniere arrives damaged or a centerpiece element breaks in transit, floral tape and a backup stem from the florist buy 10 minutes.
- [ ] **Scissors (small, sharp)** — For tags, threads, packaging tape on delivery boxes, and a dozen small things you cannot predict.
- [ ] **Black gaffer tape** — For any wire, cable, or structural element that needs immediate stabilization. Gaffer tape is the backstage solution to everything.

CATEGORY 5: FOOD & HYDRATION (3 ITEMS)

- [ ] **Two water bottles (one per partner)** — Staying hydrated keeps voices clear, minds sharp, and skin dewy for photos. You will not drink enough water if it's not handed to you.
- [ ] **Protein bars or nuts** — The couple often does not eat at their own wedding. A protein bar in the kit means you're not faint during the first dance.
- [ ] **Small piece of dark chocolate or candy** — Blood sugar crashes are real, especially after champagne on an empty stomach. Something sweet and fast is not a luxury — it's a medical decision.

CATEGORY 6: FOR THE COUPLE (3 ITEMS)

- [ ] **Vow cards** — Handwritten or printed on small, sturdy cards. Not on a phone. Not on a flapping sheet of paper. Cards that fit in a hand and don't shake.
- [ ] **A sealed note from your partner** — Written the night before. Read privately before the ceremony begins. This is the thing couples wish they had done more than almost anything else.
- [ ] **One small snack for after the ceremony** — A granola bar or crackers tucked in the emergency kit for the 15-minute window after the ceremony ends and before cocktail hour begins. The couple rarely eats at cocktail hour either. This one snack has prevented more tearful, hypoglycemic couples than any amount of vendor coordination.

--- END OF BONUS 4 ---